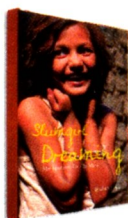


Grime to Gloss

A quickie scans Rubina's dazzling fairytale but forgets its flip side



SLUMGIRL DREAMING: MY JOURNEY TO THE STARS
by RUBINA ALI
Random House India
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 175

| By Kaveree Bamzai |

There's nothing the French like more than India's poverty. They idolised Satyajit Ray, mythologised Phoolan Devi and now it's the turn of poor little Rubina Ali to be eroticised. Perhaps it takes their mind off a trippy president, a collapsing economy and a simmering racial crisis. The result is a supposed autobiography by the nine-year-old Rubina, which chronicles her short life, which in the breathless purple prose of celebritydom is interpreted as "my journey to the stars".

But even as the star catcher in you looks for Angelina Jolie asking for Rubina's autograph on the Oscar red carpet, sniggers at "American" actress Nicole Kidman behaving in a "strange" way, and shares her exclamatory excitement at talking to Hrithik Roshan, it is the little things that keep playing back in your mind in this book that was commissioned by French publishers, Oh! Editions. Little Rubina snuggling up to Azhar and his mother in their gigantic bed in a Los Angeles hotel room because she is unused to sleeping by herself. Rubina again jumping into a hotel pool with all her clothes on because the only way she knows how to bathe is to plunge into a drainage tank near her shanty. Rubina going to pay toilets near her home after coming from America, because "I'm too big now to show my backside to the world".

Yes there is enough pathos here for a *Slumdog Millionaire* sequel. The girl who dreams of being a global actress or an astronaut will soon have to come to terms with a father who wants her to wear a burqa by the time she is 12. The girl who has sipped champagne with Hollywood stars is accustomed to rats climbing up her calf while at home. The girl who was happy with the few rupees her father gave her for candy now thinks nothing of spending Rs 800 on a pretty dress. And the girl who begged to be taken to Juhu beach is already attaching a caveat to a forthcoming trip to Paris: "I hope it has better food than America."

There's something charming about that



RUBINA ALI

naivete. Her wonder at the limousine which is as long as a train that takes them to the Oscars, of the 10 bodyguards who accompany them to Disneyland and of the fat dogs and parrot she meets at Sonia Gandhi's home. And mostly of her wide-eyed wonder: that there are no poor people in America. At one level, the book is a heartwarming fairytale. At another level it is a classic case of ruthless exploitation. Rubina is first thoughtlessly thrust into film work by her father, then ripped off by the middleman who gets her an audition with Danny Boyle, and now relentlessly chased by the media which has an insatiable curiosity in her life.

In a way, her story mirrors that of any other child star, from the late Michael Jackson to the current teenybopper queen Miley Cyrus. Where do their childhoods go? What humanity are they left with when even those closest to them regard them as a meal ticket? And what happens to them when the spotlight is switched off? This book is not the place where you will find such answers. It can barely get its spellings right, mistaking sequence for sequins and wound for would. Perhaps they were aiming at authenticity. It certainly looks like it could have been written by a nine-year-old but that is not necessarily a good thing. Even supermarket quickies should have some standards.



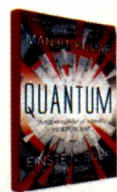
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